

Chapter 129 - Picking Flowers

"Say no more," Chu Qingqiu scolded. She carefully pulled apart Ning Fuyi's blood-stained torn clothing and took out wound medicine from the Mind Bead¹, sprinkling it on her back.

Wounds caused by heavenly thunder could not be healed with immortal power. Ning Fuyi was in such pain that cold sweat poured out. She raised her hand to bite her own wrist to keep from moaning.

After Chu Qingqiu finished applying the ointment, she leaned back against the bare rock and turned her face to one side, seemingly lost in thought.

Ning Fuyi had always felt that Chu Qingqiu rarely showed emotions—even anger was hidden beneath her calm expression. Now seeing her eyes rimmed with red gave her an illusory feeling.

"How much longer will this punishment last?" Ning Fuyi suddenly asked.

Chu Qingqiu shook her head to indicate she didn't know.

"I've been here for many, many years and have long lost track of time," she breathed gently, then suddenly bent forward, sweeping her hair to the front, exposing her thin shoulders and back to Ning Fuyi's view. "I'll carry you."

Ning Fuyi's first reaction was mockery: "The Divine Venerable's back—I, a demon lord, dare not touch it."

However, after she said this, the woman in front didn't move, still slightly bending her waist, her blood-scarred hands supporting herself against the rocks.

Ning Fuyi blinked her phoenix eyes, then with some surprise, slowly placed her hands on her and stiffly lay down.

The woman steadily carried her, moving forward on the grass-covered ground. Though her steps were uneven, she never dropped her. Ning Fuyi pressed close against Chu Qingqiu's back, the wound on her own back feeling cool as the wind blew.

Ning Fuyi stared intently at the white, tender nape of her neck, so smooth that no lines could be seen. The fine hair was coated with light, like the sweetest peach on a branch.

The gardenia fragrance wafted into her nostrils in strands, more pleasant than when they first met. Intoxicating.

Time passed longer and longer. After countless cycles of day and night, the punishments came less frequently than before.

Ning Fuyi felt this realm seemed to have the power to purify the heart. Her emotions became increasingly calm daily, as if some force was separating her from the demonic energy within her body. But this also caused the demonic energy to become unstable, frequently impacting her lungs and viscera. Every time it acted up, it would injure her internal organs.

The most serious instance lasted several days—she was pale-faced and avoided Chu Qingqiu, finding a cave to hole up in alone to nurse her injuries.

When she first woke this day, heavy rain was pouring down. Ning Fuyi lit several bonfires in the cave. When the surroundings dried out, she sat at the cave entrance listening to the rain.

The cave was trumpet-shaped. Bean-sized raindrops slid down the smooth rocks, pounding small pits in the ground. A pure white wildflower was beaten down by the rainwater, then tremblingly blown free of water droplets by the wind.

As the rain curtain gradually thinned and the light outside the cave became clear and transparent with emerald mist, Ning Fuyi bent down to pick that wildflower and held it in her hand to play with.

A figure emerged from the mist, holding a bamboo leaf umbrella, walking gracefully. She blocked the heavenly light from Ning Fuyi's face, so Ning Fuyi silently moved to another spot and continued gazing into the distance.

Chu Qingqiu had no mind to play games with her. She raised her hand to close the umbrella and set it aside, lifting her skirt that was wet to the knees, then walked to her side and squatted down.

"The Divine Venerable graces us with her presence—this humble dwelling only has a few bonfires for hospitality," Ning Fuyi said teasingly.

"Your demonic energy is unstable. I saw it," Chu Qingqiu didn't engage with her banter.

"So what if you saw it? Can the Divine Venerable help me, or can you send me out of this cursed place?" Ning Fuyi squinted her phoenix eyes, continuing to play with the delicate flower in her hand with boredom.

The snow-white delicate flower, dotted with water droplets, trembled gently between her slender fingertips—it was quite pleasing to the eye.

Chu Qingqiu looked away. After a long silence and much hesitation, she suddenly produced two wine jars from who knows where. The jar bodies were smooth as jade, wrapped with golden silk at the mouth. As soon as they appeared, an intoxicating wine fragrance spread—clearly fine wine.

Ning Fuyi, who had been dejected just moments before, finally raised her eyelids, bright light reflecting in her deep eyes.

Though she wasn't addicted to fine wine and delicacies, after staying so long in this place with nothing, she still felt some longing for the outside world's decadent pleasures.

"Your broken bead has quite a few treasures in it. I never thought the Divine Venerable would secretly have a fondness for wine," Ning Fuyi reached out to take the jar, smiling until dimples formed at the corners of her mouth.

"I never touch such things," Chu Qingqiu frowned. "This was stored by your mother, kept in the Mind Bead for who knows how many years. I don't know if it's still drinkable."

"Then you don't understand—this is a worry-dispelling thing," Ning Fuyi reached out to break the seal and took a deep breath, closing her eyes with a smile. "One sip of worry-dispelling wine erases ten thousand ancient sorrows."

With that, she tilted her head back and took a sip. Clear wine dripped from her red lips, trickling into her collar: "Worthy of what my mother left behind. You should try some too."

"I never drink wine," Chu Qingqiu raised her hand to block.

Who would have thought Ning Fuyi completely ignored her refusal, raising her hand to press the wine pot to her lips. Chu Qingqiu couldn't resist and was forced to swallow two mouthfuls, choking until her pale face turned red.

"Ning Fuyi, stop fooling around!" Chu Qingqiu covered her lips. The spicy wine slid down her throat, making her whole body feel prickly, then burning hot inside.

"You're being a Divine Venerable, not a nun," Ning Fuyi said, taking a few more sips, then satisfiedly handed the remainder to Chu Qingqiu. "A bit more?"

At this time, the burning sensation in her abdomen began spreading throughout her body, feeling like basking in warm sunlight. Chu Qingqiu felt a mysterious, hazy sensation, more floating than flying in the clouds.

So she took the wine pot from Ning Fuyi's hand, pressed it to her lips, and drank a little.

"That's right—just drink that much." Ning Fuyi opened another jar and drank by herself, accompanied by the grass fragrance in the rain.

Chu Qingqiu beside her found she didn't dislike this thing, so she also sipped slowly.

The rain became increasingly sparse, but the bonfire crackled and burned more vigorously. Chu Qingqiu felt increasingly dizzy, so she put down the jar and got up to walk into the rain.

The small raindrops falling on her body weren't cold but rather cool and pleasant. Chu Qingqiu's vision swayed unsteadily, and she remembered she hadn't brought the umbrella out, so she prepared to go back for it.

Just as she turned around, she crashed into Ning Fuyi, who had followed her out. The woman looked up, placing her pale, slender hand above her head, blocking a small patch of rain curtain in front of her.

Perhaps it was the wine taking effect—the hostility in her eyes was gone, replaced by soft, misty moisture that seemed to penetrate one's soul. The tear moles² took on an alluring air.

Chu Qingqiu suddenly felt that the already swaying green mountains began spinning wildly. She hurriedly waved away her hand, and the woman patted her head: "Umbrella."

When she went back to the cave to get it, Chu Qingqiu pinched herself and turned to leave.

Rather than leaving, it was more like fleeing in panic.

After an hour, the long night arrived again. Today there was no sunset glow—only darkness remained. Chu Qingqiu waited in the bamboo house, half-drunk and half-awake, for a long time, but didn't see that figure return.

Her heart was always suspended, so she simply went out and followed her memory all the way back until she returned to the cave, finally seeing the woman's figure.

The bonfire was still burning. Ning Fuyi was half-leaning against it, her face already withered like fallen leaves, surrounded by black energy, obviously impacting her lungs and viscera again, attempting to devour her mind once more.

Chu Qingqiu quickly stepped forward and sealed several of her acupoints, but they were soon broken through, causing her delicate brows to furrow tightly.

"The Primordial Chaos accidentally restored your original mind, but the demonic energy within you is unwilling and insists on continuing to devour you. This is what causes the chaotic demonic energy that harms your lungs and viscera," Chu Qingqiu said quickly. She tried to summon immortal power, but the remaining meager strength was completely useless.

Ning Fuyi trembled all over, understanding most of her words, then smiled wearily: "It's just enduring another night. Once I leave this chaos, I imagine it will be fine."

A wisp of demonic energy emerged from her brow as she let out a low growl of pain.

"You should go quickly. I don't want to kill you now. If I accidentally kill you, wouldn't that be too unjust?" Ning Fuyi pushed her away and curled up alone in the corner.

Chu Qingqiu's body swayed from the push, then she stood still, rippling firelight flowing through her eyes.

"If this happens a few more times, your life won't be preserved either," Chu Qingqiu said.

"If I die, then I die. I've lived enough of this wretched life. If I can see Ning Changfeng³ again down there, this trip to the world won't be in vain," Ning Fuyi laughed loudly.

Chu Qingqiu closed her eyes tightly for a moment, then opened them faintly. Suddenly she raised her hand and manifested a ethereal light shadow. Looking closely, it was a proudly blooming gardenia flower.

Ning Fuyi's expression went from confusion to shock, finally gasping: "You, you are..."

Before she could finish, delicate silver threads emerged from the woman's brow, circling and probing in mid-air before suddenly drilling into her mind. Ning Fuyi immediately felt like thunder entering her body and tensed her back rigidly.

The strange sensation made her limbs go soft. When she looked up again, the woman had somehow bent down above her. A white light point floated in mid-air, illuminating her face as bright as the moon, while a red flush that didn't match the brightness surged in her eyes.

Her eyelids were covered by cool palms as Chu Qingqiu said in a low voice: "You must not develop feelings."

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Flowers blooming in the bitter cold, standing on high mountain cliffs—suddenly within reach one day, immediately feeling like entering a dream, very illusory.

The already long night became even longer—so long that every time she woke she felt still in a dream. But no matter how slowly, time still flowed. Finally dawn rose, completed a cycle, then set again.

You must not develop feelings.

Chu Qingqiu did very well. Perhaps she originally had no feelings. Even with souls intertwining, even with the closest contact between them, those peach blossom eyes showed no desire. Even when exhausted to the point of collapse at the end of dual cultivation⁴, she wouldn't shed a single tear.

But Ning Fuyi failed to do so.

When such a noble and elegant woman approached her and fell softly onto her while gasping, she knew she had no way back.

She often cursed herself—no matter how much she had hated before, it turned out that as long as Chu Qingqiu showed her even a little kindness, all past grievances would disappear on their own, leaving only admiration.

She could clearly feel the wavering in her heart. Her hatred was stirred into chaos by another burning emotion. She began often staring at Chu Qingqiu's flushed sleeping face in a daze, occasionally drawing close as if possessed by a ghost, but not daring to kiss her.

She smiled bitterly. Even though she felt she had already committed countless evil deeds, she still wasn't willing to cross that line.

Nor willing to pluck the divine flower.

This way was fine too. She felt that whether they could get out or not no longer mattered. The outside world wasn't necessarily better than now. If they had to spend the rest of their lives trapped in this chaos, it wouldn't be despairing either.

But things often go against one's wishes. The thunder punishments hadn't come for a very long time—so long that Ning Fuyi had forgotten about the threat of heavenly thunder. But she could see Chu Qingqiu's increasing worry and growing sorrow.

Finally, on a morning with brilliant sunset clouds, the sky conceived thunder and lightning again. Dark clouds visibly tore apart the morning glow and pressed down heavily.

Chu Qingqiu, who had stayed up all night by candlelight, extinguished the candle and tiptoed to Ning Fuyi's side, removing the Mind Bead from her wrist and firmly tying it to her arm.

The Reincarnation Array⁵ had been sealed within the Mind Bead. When she was at the end of her rope, she would naturally see it.

Then, Chu Qingqiu didn't wake the sleeping Ning Fuyi on the mat. She pushed open the door and walked out of the bamboo house, heading toward the distant plain.

To accept the final thunder strike—one that was almost fatal for her current state.

After this thunder passed, the Primordial Chaos would completely disappear, and they could end this nightmare and return to their original world. And Ning Fuyi...

She was originally an intruder, a mistake of the Heavenly Dao. Once she left this Primordial Chaos, she probably wouldn't remember anything from today. These absurdities would ultimately only return to dust along with herself.

Chu Qingqiu walked very far, until she was too tired to walk anymore, then staggered down to sit, looking back toward the simple little house behind several slopes.

The heavenly thunder came as expected, brilliant enough to illuminate layers of dark clouds. The earth trembled accordingly, fierce winds wailed, and a light ball the size of a mountain peak fell.

Chu Qingqiu closed her eyes and waited. However, just as the scorching fierce wind was about to hit her face, another figure burst through the air with rolling black energy, blocking mid-air. The heavenly thunder exploded thunderously on her back, and the airflow that could collapse heaven and earth suddenly scattered in a ring, leveling all the mountains and rivers in sight.

Then the wind slowed, everything seemed to stop, and an even more dazzling light split open the chaos. The ground and sky both turned into void, and the void wrapped toward the two of them. She was full of shock as the woman pressed her into her arms.

At the moment this realm completely disappeared and she fell alone onto Purple Cloud Peak⁶, she heard Ning Fuyi's breath stir slightly as she whispered to her left ear:

"Chu Qingqiu."

"I don't hate you anymore."

- ¹ **Mind Bead (一念珠)** - A cultivation artifact that stores memories, thoughts, or spiritual items
- ² **Tear moles (泪痣)** - Beauty marks located under the eyes, traditionally considered to enhance attractiveness in Chinese culture
- ³ **Ning Changfeng (宁长风)** - Ning Fuyi's mother from the previous life
- ⁴ **Dual Cultivation (双修)** - A cultivation practice where two people cultivate together, sharing and enhancing each other's spiritual energy
- ⁵ **Reincarnation Array (轮回阵)** - A magical formation related to cycles of rebirth and reincarnation
- ⁶ **Purple Cloud Peak (紫霞峰)** - Chu Qingqiu's residence at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate